CODEALPHA CYBERSECURITY INTERNSHIP

PHISHING AWARENESS TRAINING

Recognising phishing attacks, suspicious links and social engineering

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Project: Cybersecurity Awareness

Objective: To educate users on identifying phishing attempts and practising safe online behaviour.

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What is Phishing?

Understanding one of the most common online threats.

A cyberattack in which an **attacker pretends to be a trusted person or organisation** to trick users into revealing sensitive information or taking unsafe actions.



Warning Signs

- Unexpected requests for passwords or personal information.
- Messages creating fear or urgency.
- Suspicious links or unexpected attachments.
- Sender addresses or website domains that do not match the claimed organisation.

Stop, check the sender, verify the link and never share passwords or verification codes in response to unexpected messages.

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How Phishing Works

A simple four-stage process.



01 — THE ATTACKER

Creates a message pretending to come from a trusted source.



02 — THE BAIT

Sends an urgent alert, fake offer or request for verification.



03 — THE ACTION

The recipient may click a link, open an attachment or disclose sensitive information.



04 — THE IMPACT

The attempt may lead to stolen information, account compromise or malware infection.

Safety reminder: Pause and verify unexpected requests through an independently trusted channel.

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Types of Phishing Attacks

Recognise the different ways attackers may approach their targets.



1. Email Phishing

Fraudulent emails impersonate trusted organisations to trick recipients into clicking links or sharing sensitive information.



2. Smishing (SMS Phishing)

Fraudulent text messages encourage people to visit fake websites or provide personal details.



3. Vishing (Voice Phishing)

Fraudsters use phone calls or voice messages while pretending to represent a bank, company or authority.



4. Spear Phishing

A targeted phishing attempt tailored to a particular person or organisation using personalised details.

Phishing can arrive through different channels. Always verify unexpected requests before responding.

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Warning Signs in Phishing Emails

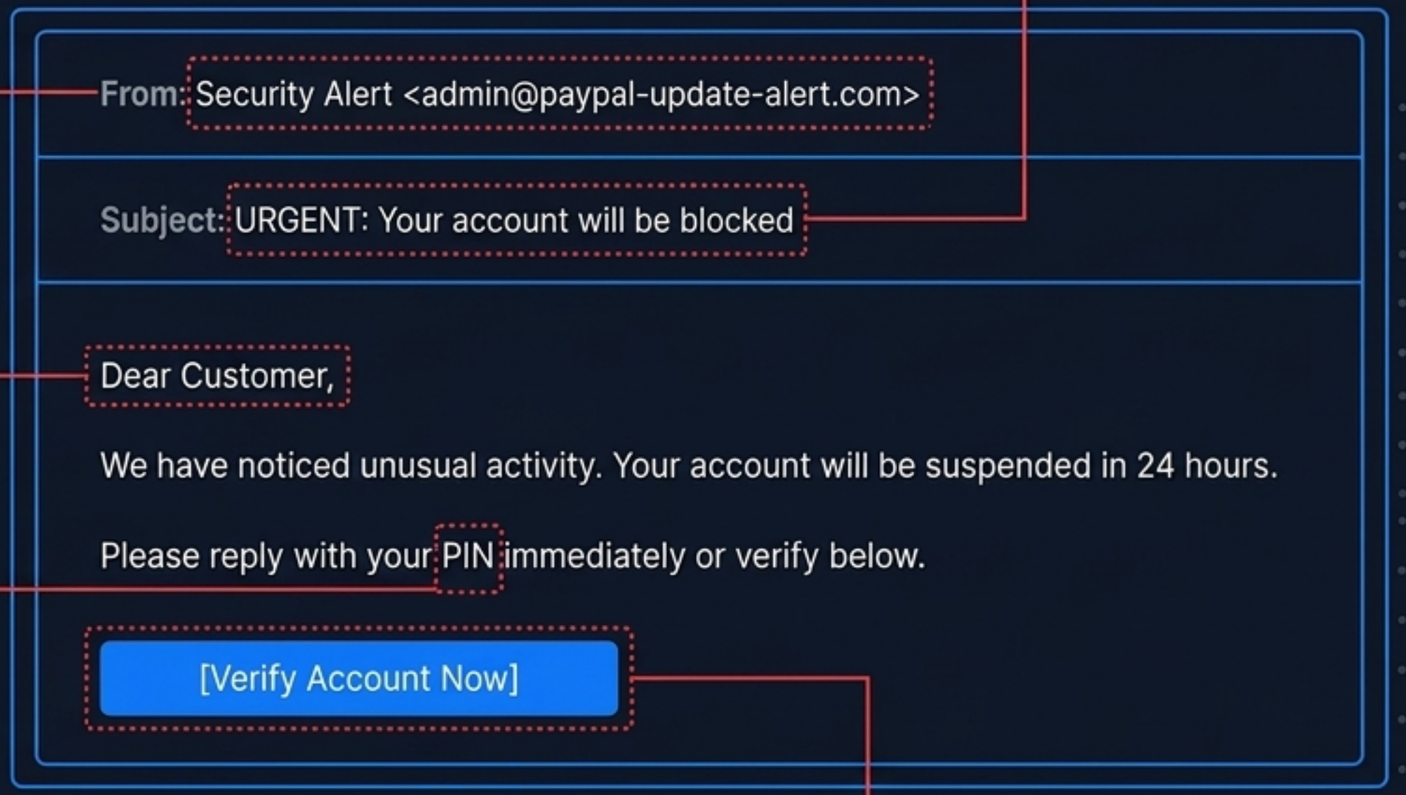
Learn what to check before clicking or replying.

1. Suspicious Sender Address: The email address may not match the organisation it claims to represent.

2. Urgent or Threatening Language: Messages may claim your account will be blocked unless you act immediately.

3. Unusual Spelling or Generic Greetings: Poor grammar or generic greetings can be warning signs (though professional-looking emails can also be fraudulent).

5. Requests for Sensitive Information: Treat unexpected requests for passwords, PINs or verification codes as suspicious.



4. Unexpected Links or Attachments: Check links carefully and avoid opening unexpected attachments.

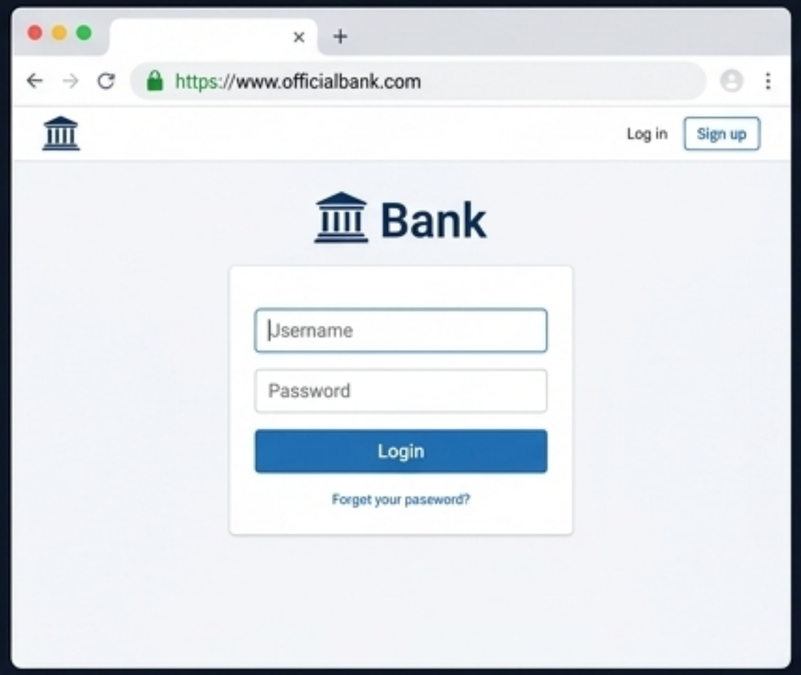
Safety tip: Verify unexpected requests using an official website, app or independently confirmed contact number.

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How to Identify Fake Websites

Check the website before entering information.

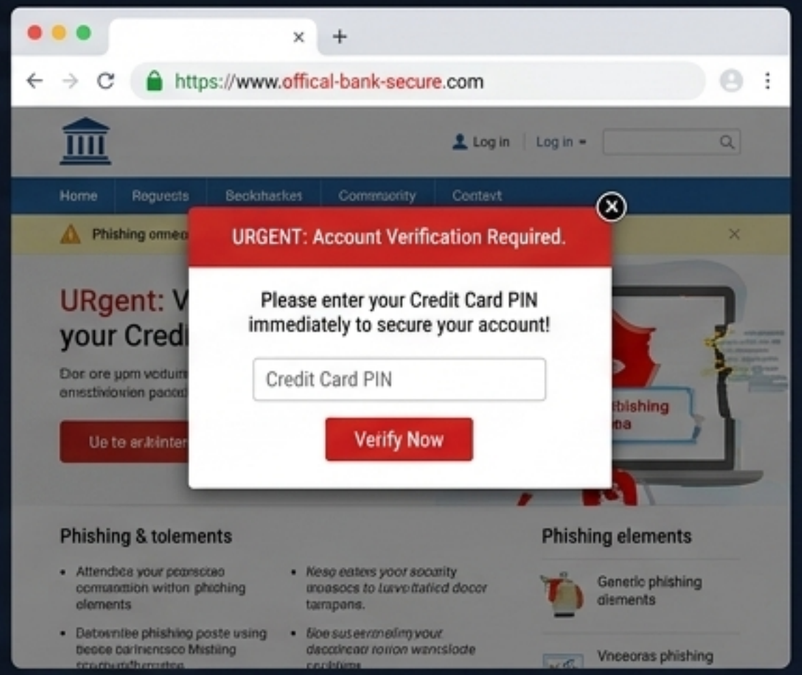
Trustworthy Interface



Imposter Matrix

- Inspect the domain name carefully for misspellings or unexpected variations.
- Confirm that the domain matches the organisation's genuine website.
- Be cautious of unexpected login requests, pop-ups or pressure to enter sensitive information.
- Navigate to important services using a known official website or trusted app rather than an unexpected message link.
- Check for inconsistencies in branding, contact information and page content.

Suspicious Interface



Technical note: HTTPS and a padlock indicate an encrypted connection; they do not prove that a website is legitimate or trustworthy.

Verify the full domain independently before entering passwords, payment information or personal details.

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Social Engineering Techniques

Understand how attackers exploit human trust and emotions.



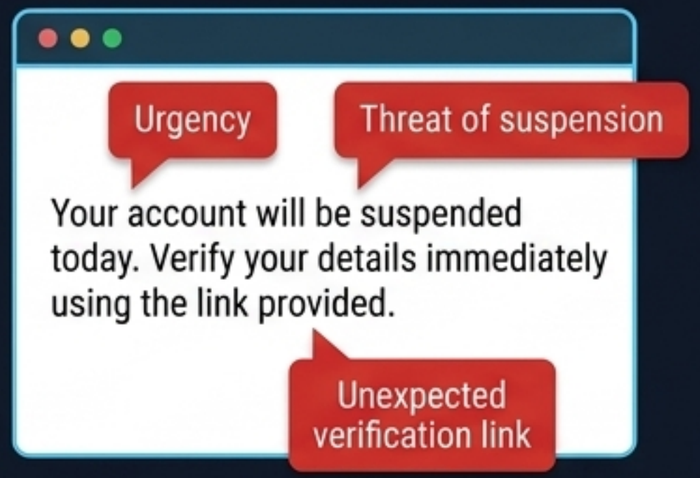
Protection: Pause, verify the person's identity independently, and never let pressure replace security checks.

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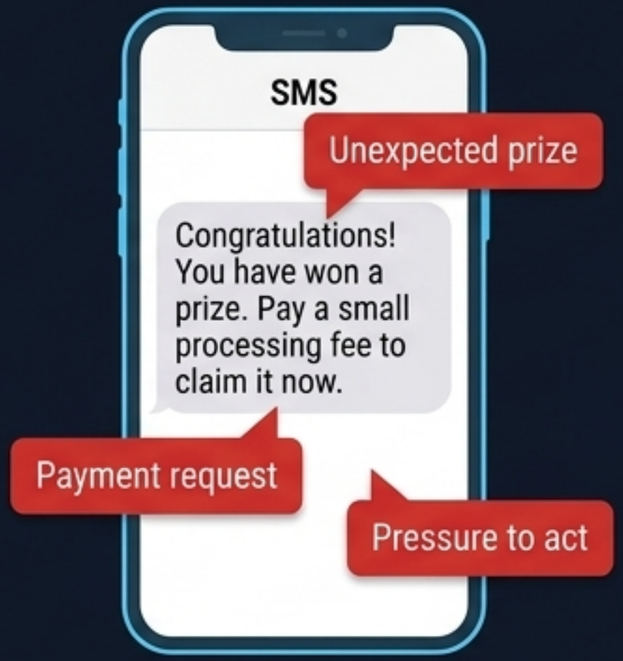
Phishing Examples: Spot the Red Flags

Three fictional scenarios for awareness training.

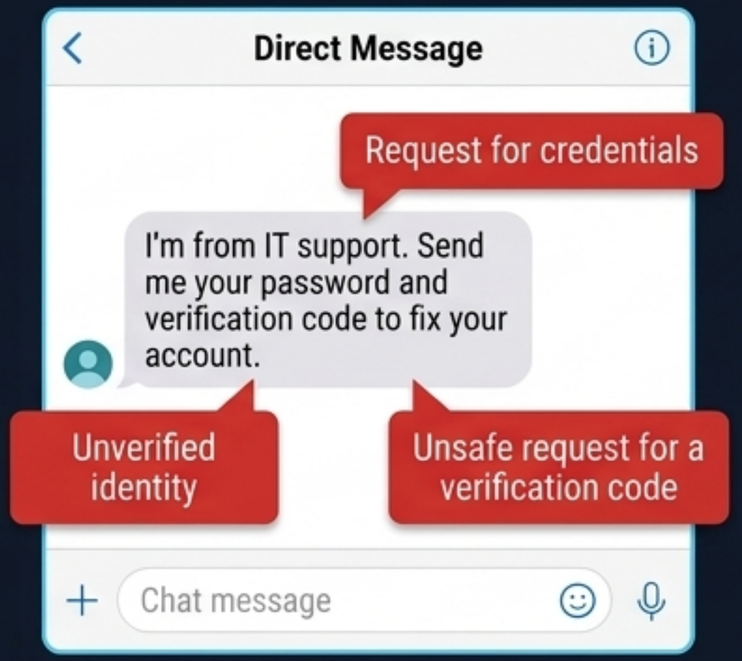
Device Screen
Example 1 (Fake Account Alert)



Device Screen
Example 2 (Fake Prize)



Device Screen
Example 3 (Impersonation)



Safe Response: Don't click, pay or share sensitive information. Verify the request through an independently trusted channel.

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Prevention and Safety Practices

Simple habits that reduce the risk of phishing.

1. Verify Before You Click: Check unexpected links and confirm requests through official channels.

2. Use Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA): Add another verification step to your account, beyond just a password.

3. Use Strong, Unique Passwords: Avoid reusing passwords across different accounts. Consider using a reputable password manager.

4. Keep Software Updated: Install security updates for your operating system, browser and applications.

5. Report Suspicious Messages: Use your organisation's approved reporting process or the email provider's phishing-reporting feature.

6. Think Before Sharing: Never disclose passwords, PINs or verification codes in response to unexpected requests.

PAUSE. VERIFY. PROTECT.

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What to Do with a Suspicious Message

Follow these steps to respond safely.

1. **Stop and Think:** Do not immediately click links, open attachments or reply.
2. **Verify the Sender:** Check the sender's identity using an independently trusted contact method.
3. **Do Not Share Sensitive Information:** Never provide passwords, PINs or verification codes in response to unexpected requests.
4. **Report the Message:** Follow your organisation's security reporting process or use the email provider's reporting option.
5. **Delete or Quarantine It:** Follow your organisation's procedures for handling suspicious messages.

6. **If You Already Clicked:** Report the incident promptly to your IT or security team. If you entered a password, change it through the official service and review your account security.

Acting quickly and reporting suspicious activity can help limit potential harm.

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Conclusion & References

Building safer online habits through phishing awareness.

- Phishing uses deception to trick people into unsafe actions.
- Suspicious links, unexpected requests and impersonation are important warning signs.
- Verify website addresses and identities before sharing sensitive information.
- Report suspicious messages promptly and follow appropriate security procedures.



PAUSE. VERIFY. PROTECT.

References:
- CISA — Secure Our World (https://www.cisa.gov/secure-our-world)
- Federal Trade Commission — How to Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams (https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-recognize-and-avoid-phishing-scams)
- National Cybersecurity Alliance — Online Safety Resources (https://staysafeonline.org/)

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